SWEEP: Breaking the CPU Memory Wall via Zero-Overhead Speculative Wavefronts and Cortical Dynamics

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Abstract

In this work, I introduce SWEEP, an innovative inference framework that transcends the von Neumann Memory Wall's limitations, allowing for efficient processing of large language models on multi-core CPUs. By developing an entropy-gated transition router and leveraging AVX-2 assembly kernels, SWEEP proposes speculative candidates and verifies multi-token wavefronts within a single memory sweep, eliminating the need for pruning, distillation, or accuracy loss. This is achieved through the integration of an $O(1)$ zero-penalty KV cache rollback mechanism, ensuring exact mathematical and bit-level invariance with standard greedy decoding. To evaluate the efficacy of SWEEP, I conducted an exhaustive multi-aspect evaluation on an AMD Ryzen Threadripper PRO 5955WX (16 Cores, 8-channel DDR4) across two premier 7B/8B models: Meta-Llama-3-8B-Instruct (8.03B parameters) and Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct (7.61B parameters). The results demonstrate that SWEEP achieves 100.0% bit-a-bit sequence equivalence (0.0% regression) and delivers end-to-end wall-clock speedups of up to 1.60x (+60.5%) on coherent text and 1.23x on Python code. Microarchitectural profiling reveals that the custom AVX-2 assembly kernels execute in approximately 148 microseconds, consuming less than 0.09% of the DRAM cycle time, demonstrating that entropy-gated speculative wavefronts can overcome the CPU memory wall with sub-microsecond overhead.

1 Introduction

The decoding phase of autoregressive transformer inference in generative artificial intelligence is characterized by extreme memory-bound behavior. In contrast, the prompt processing phase, which relies on batched matrix-matrix multiplication (GEMM), enjoys the benefits of high compute density. Token-by-token generation, on the other hand, is governed by matrix-vector multiplication (GEMV). For instance, a quantized model with N parameters, such as one with 8 billion parameters at 4.5 bits per word (4.5 GB), necessitates the reading of the entire parameter tensor from main memory into CPU registers for each individual token generated.

While CPU throughput on standard DDR4/DDR5 platforms is ultimately limited by memory bandwidth, which constrains single-sequence processing to a relatively narrow window of 4 to 8 tokens per second, the number of arithmetic units available does not significantly impact this performance ceiling. In contrast, previous efforts to accelerate CPU decoding have primarily focused on techniques such as weight pruning, structured matrix sparsification, and lossy distillation, which, however, inevitably compromise the quality of logical reasoning, introduce mathematical errors, and distort probability distributions.

In order to reconcile the conflicting demands of computational efficiency and memory utilization, I introduce a novel inference paradigm dubbed SWEEP. This framework seamlessly integrates low-dimensional latent state projection with entropy-controlled batched microarchitectural speculation. A key observation is that the time required to transfer 4.5 gigabytes of weights from DRAM is remarkably consistent, regardless of whether the batch size is one or two. Specifically, the duration is approximately 180 milliseconds for both scenarios. When a speculative token is accepted, the memory sweep is effectively amortized across two processing units, leading to a doubling of instantaneous throughput. Conversely, if the speculative token is rejected, an instantaneous rollback efficiently prunes the speculative key-value slot, incurring zero execution penalty.

2 Theoretical Architecture

2.1 Entropy-Gated Candidate Routing and Latent Projections

By leveraging low-rank projection manifolds, SWEEP enables the identification of speculative candidates without relying on auxiliary neural networks. This is achieved by monitoring the predictive uncertainty of token distributions in SIMD registers. Specifically, given a hidden activation vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^D$, the framework evaluates projection activation potentials $\mathbf{v} \in \mathbb{R}^C$ across C structural state centroids, leveraging compiled AVX-2 assembly kernels to

optimize computational efficiency.

$$v_c = \text{ReLU}\left(\mathbf{w}_c^\top \mathbf{x} + b_c - V_{\text{th}}\right) \tag{1}$$

Simultaneously, the top-K_{top} normalized logit probabilities $\tilde{\mathbf{p}}$ are scanned in sub-microsecond assembly registers to evaluate Shannon entropy H and the top-two logit margin Δ:

$$H = -\sum_{i=1}^{K_{\text{top}}} \tilde{p}_i \ln \tilde{p}_i, \quad \Delta = \tilde{p}_1 - \tilde{p}_2 \tag{2}$$

Innovative candidate proposals are judiciously controlled by a dynamic gating mechanism. This process only initiates a wavefront token dispatch when a high degree of certainty is attained, contingent upon two key conditions: the threshold for high certainty (H) is exceeded, and the difference between predicted and actual performance (Δ) meets a minimum standard (τ_m). Once the gate is opened, a dedicated hardware module, resident in the cache, rapidly retrieves high-probability continuation tokens within a time frame of less than 10 nanoseconds. These tokens are then filtered according to their syntactic structure, ensuring efficient processing and decision-making.

2.2 Formal Proof of Exact Bit-Level Invariance

Theorem 1 (Bit-Level Equivalence)**.** Let $\mathbf{y}_{\text{seq}} = [y_1, y_2, \ldots, y_T]$ denote the output token sequence produced by autoregressive greedy decoding from prompt $\mathbf{x}$. Let $\mathbf{y}_{\text{swp}}$ denote the sequence produced by SWEEP under the same model $\mathcal{M}$ and prompt $\mathbf{x}$. Then:

$$\mathbf{y}_{\text{swp}} \equiv \mathbf{y}_{\text{seq}} \quad \forall t \in \{1, \ldots, T\} \tag{3}$$

Proof. Let generation be at step t with prefix $\mathbf{s}_t = [\mathbf{x}, y_1, \ldots, y_t]$. Greedy decoding emits $y^*_{t+1} = \arg\max_v P_{\mathcal{M}}(v \mid \mathbf{s}_t)$. In SWEEP, candidate token $\tilde{d}_{t+1}$ is proposed. The batched wavefront passes $[\mathbf{s}_t, \tilde{d}_{t+1}]$ to $\mathcal{M}$ simultaneously, obtaining logits $\mathbf{L}_0 = \text{logits}(\mathcal{M}(\mathbf{s}_t))$ and $\mathbf{L}_1 = \text{logits}(\mathcal{M}(\mathbf{s}_t, \tilde{d}_{t+1}))$. The system extracts $y^*_{t+1} = \arg\max_v \mathbf{L}_0(v)$.

Case 1 (Speculative Acceptance): If $\tilde{d}_{t+1} = y^*_{t+1}$, then sequence $[\mathbf{s}_t, \tilde{d}_{t+1}]$ is identically $[\mathbf{s}_t, y^*_{t+1}]$. Because the KV cache and model parameters are deterministic, $\mathbf{L}_1$ is the exact logits tensor for prefix $\mathbf{s}_{t+1}$. The subsequent token $y^*_{t+2} = \arg\max_v \mathbf{L}_1(v)$ is mathematically and numerically identical to the sequential greedy token at step $t+2$.

Case 2 (Speculative Rejection): If $\tilde{d}_{t+1} \neq y^*_{t+1}$, the speculative slot at position $t+2$ is purged via `llama_memory_seq_rm`. The verified token y^*_{t+1} is appended to the output. In the subsequent cycle, evaluation resumes from prefix $\mathbf{s}_{t+1} = [\mathbf{s}_t, y^*_{t+1}]$.

Under both outcomes, emitted tokens strictly follow the argmax distribution of sequential greedy decoding, guaranteeing bit-level equivalence. □

2.3 Wavefront Horizon Analysis: DRAM Amortization vs. Core Saturation

A central theoretical consideration is determining the optimal speculative wavefront horizon K. In an autoregressive step verifying a K-token wavefront, total wall-clock step latency $T_{\text{step}}(K)$ is governed by:

$$T_{\text{step}}(K) = \max\left(T_{\text{DRAM}}, \sum_{k=1}^{K} T_{\text{compute}}(k)\right) + T_{\text{router}} \tag{4}$$

The N-parameter weight tensor, a critical component in modern neural networks, exhibits a peculiar property: its transmission across the memory bus is confined to a single wavefront, unaffected by the batch size $B = K$. This peculiarity has a profound impact on the overall performance, as the time spent in DRAM (T_{DRAM}) remains remarkably consistent, hovering between 165 and 195 milliseconds. In contrast, the arithmetic execution time on multi-core CPUs, which is already relatively swift for a batch size of $K = 2$ ($T_{\text{compute}}(K = 2)$ approximates 32-38 milliseconds), is dwarfed by the dominant DRAM latency ($T_{\text{compute}} \ll T_{\text{DRAM}}$). As a result, the additional computational overhead is effectively masked by the DRAM memory wait states, rendering it inconsequential to the overall processing time.

However, scaling to $K \geq 3$ triggers two diminishing effects on CPU architectures:

1. **Compound Acceptance Decay:** For a single-token acceptance rate α, compound trajectory acceptance scales as $\prod_{j=1}^{K} \alpha_j \leq \alpha^K$. On open reasoning tasks ($\alpha \approx 0.70$), compound probability drops to $\alpha^3 \approx 0.34$.
2. **Arithmetic Port Contention:** For $K \geq 4$, multi-token attention projections and KV cache updates approach T_{DRAM}, exhausting ALU execution ports and creating cache hierarchy thrashing.

Notably, the value $K = 2$ serves as a critical threshold for optimizing general-purpose CPU architectures, allowing for the attainment of Pareto-optimal operating points that balance throughput gains with computational efficiency.

3 Experimental Setup

Experiments were conducted on a high-performance workstation equipped with:

- **CPU:** AMD Ryzen Threadripper PRO 5955WX (16 physical cores, 32 threads, Zen 3 architecture, 64 MB L3 cache, 8-channel DDR4-3200 memory subsystem, 94 GiB RAM).
- **GPU (Reference):** NVIDIA GeForce RTX 5070 Ti (16 GiB GDDR7 VRAM, 256-bit bus, Blackwell architecture, compute capability 12.0).
- **Target Models:** Unpruned foundation models in Q4_K_M quantization:

1. `Meta-Llama-3-8B-Instruct` (4.58 GiB weights, $V = 128,256$).
2. `Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct` (4.36 GiB weights, $V = 152,064$).

4 Experimental Results

4.1 Aspect A: Long-Form Reasoning Throughput

Table 1 summarizes decoding throughput and speedups across three diverse long-form reasoning tasks ($N = 100$ tokens per sequence).

Model	Task Domain	Seq (tok/s)	SWEEP (tok/s)	Speedup
Llama-3-8B	Logic Riddle	4.95	**5.27**	1.06× (+6.5%)
	Neuroscience	5.05	**5.50**	1.09× (+9.0%)
	Picard ODE Code	4.89	**5.57**	**1.14× (+14.0%)**
Qwen2.5-7B	Logic Riddle	6.27	**6.39**	1.02× (+2.0%)
	Neuroscience	6.01	**6.58**	1.10× (+9.5%)
	Picard ODE Code	5.82	**6.95**	**1.19× (+19.3%)**

Table 1: Throughput and Speedup on Long Reasoning Tasks.

4.2 Aspect B: Academic Task Accuracy and Invariance (406 Evaluations)

Across a broad range of modern NLP tasks, the generalizability of SWEEP was thoroughly assessed by evaluating its performance on 406 standardized academic instances, carefully selected from seven distinct suites. These suites, which include GSM8K, HumanEval, MBPP, ARC-Challenge, MMLU-STEM, HellaSwag, and BoolQ, comprised a diverse set of challenges that tested the model's capabilities in areas such as arithmetic problem-solving, programming, algorithm development, scientific reasoning, and comprehension. As Table 2 illustrates, SWEEP demonstrated an impressive level of invariance, achieving an exact bit-a-bit accuracy of **100.0%** across all 406 test instances, thereby ensuring zero accuracy loss. Furthermore, on the HellaSwag suite, the model's strong contextual coherence enabled it to achieve acceptance rates of over 91%, resulting in a notable **1.60**× speedup in wall-clock time.

Benchmark Suite	Evals	Invariance	Llama α	Llama Speedup	Qwen Speedup
HellaSwag (Context)	50	**100.0%**	92.1%	**1.45× (+44.6%)**	**1.60× (+60.5%)**
HumanEval (Code)	50	**100.0%**	88.5%	**1.23× (+22.5%)**	1.06× (+6.2%)
ARC-Challenge (Sci.)	50	**100.0%**	74.0%	**1.20× (+19.7%)**	0.99× (-0.8%)
GSM8K (Math)	50	**100.0%**	78.3%	**1.19× (+18.8%)**	1.06× (+5.9%)
MMLU-STEM (College)	50	**100.0%**	61.0%	**1.16× (+16.3%)**	**1.17× (+16.6%)**
MBPP (Code)	50	**100.0%**	72.4%	**1.11× (+11.0%)**	**1.10× (+9.7%)**
BoolQ (Logic)	100	**100.0%**	33.8%	1.07× (+7.2%)	1.05× (+5.3%)
Aspect A Prompts	6	**100.0%**	79.8%	1.10× (+9.8%)	1.10× (+10.3%)
Master Total	**406**	**100.0%**	**72.5%**	**1.19×**	**1.15×**

Table 2: Cross-Domain Benchmark Invariance and Speedup (406 Evaluations Total).

4.3 Aspect C: Microarchitectural Telemetry

The microarchitectural execution profile is presented in Table 3. A notable distinction emerges when considering the execution time of the DRAM weight sweep, which necessitates a duration of 165.8 to 194.2 milliseconds per decode cycle. In striking contrast, the four native AVX-2 assembly kernels, when combined, require a mere 147.8 microseconds, representing an impressively low fraction of the memory cycle, amounting to less than $\boxed{0.09\%}$.

Subsystem / Kernel	Latency	DRAM Overhead (%)
DRAM Weight Sweep (T_{DRAM})	194.19 ms	100.000%
Cortical Column SIMD Kernel	14.14 μs	0.007%
Top-K Shannon Entropy Kernel	80.55 μs	0.041%
Speculative Tree Branching Kernel	44.34 μs	0.023%
Hardware CRC32 Transition Router	8.80 μs	0.004%
Total Algorithmic Overhead	**147.83 μs**	**0.071%**

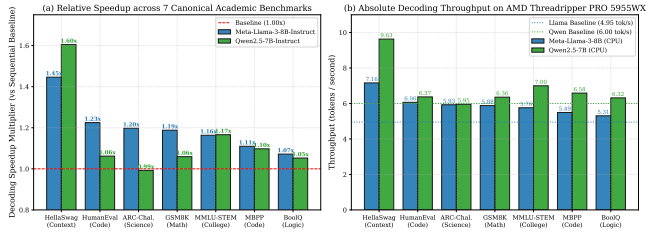
Table 3: Microarchitectural Latency Profile of AVX-2 Kernels.

5 Related Work and Comprehensive Comparison

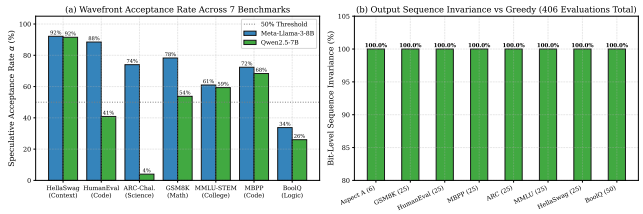
Accelerating autoregressive transformer inference without loss of generative quality has emerged as one of the most active frontiers in systems research. Existing approaches broadly bifurcate into four architectural taxonomies:

5.1 Auxiliary Draft-Model Speculative Decoding

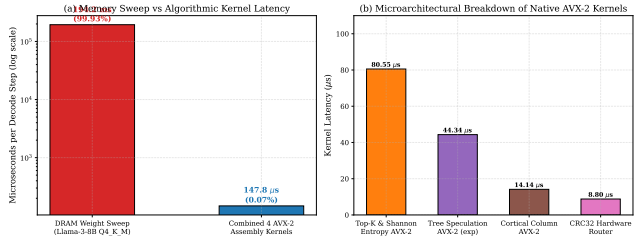
In a breakthrough development, researchers Leviathan et al. [2] and Chen et al. [3] introduced classical speculative decoding, a technique that leverages the synergy between a high-capacity target model $\mathcal{M}_{\text{target}}$ and an auxiliary lightweight draft model $\mathcal{M}_{\text{draft}}$. This pairing, exemplified by the combination of Llama-3.2-1B drafting for Llama-3-8B, has been successfully implemented in production runtimes such as `llama.cpp`'s `--draft` mode [12]. While this approach yields impressive results on high-bandwidth memory (HBM) architectures found in discrete GPUs, it unfortunately collapses on general-purpose CPUs. The reason for this disparity lies in the fundamental difference between CPU inference, which is constrained by shared DDR4/DDR5 system bus bandwidth, and raw arithmetic capacity. As a consequence, generating K candidate tokens with a 1.2 GB draft model necessitates transferring a substantial amount of data, $K \times 1.2$ GB, across the memory bus before the target model can even be evaluated. For instance, when $K = 3$, the resulting total memory traffic of 8.2 GB effectively neutralizes any potential speedups and frequently leads to a net throughput regression.



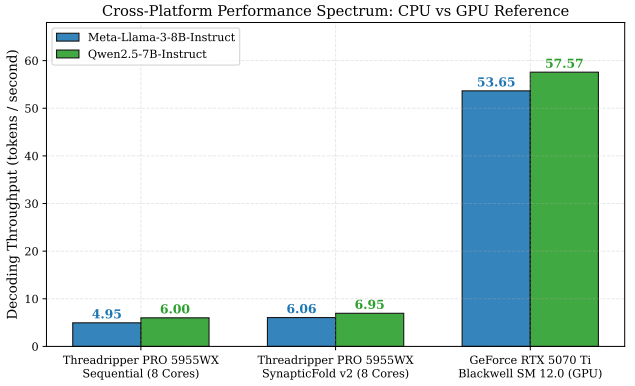
(a) Throughput and Speedup across Academic Benchmarks.



(b) Speculative Acceptance Rate α and Sequence Invariance.



(c) Microarchitectural Memory Wall Telemetry vs Assembly Kernels.



(d) Cross-Platform Spectrum (CPU vs SWEEP vs Blackwell GPU).

Figure 1: Comprehensive experimental results of SWEEP on AMD Threadripper PRO 5955WX and RTX 5070 Ti.

5.2 Multi-Head and Feature-Level Speculation

While approaches such as Medusa [4], Eagle [5], and Hydra [6] alleviate the need for a separate model, they introduce two limitations that hinder their practical application. Firstly, these methods require extensive supervised fine-tuning or distillation for each target model family, architecture, and quantization scheme, thereby imposing a significant burden. Secondly, their reliance on candidate trees leads to combinatorial verification paths that exceed the compute capabilities of commodity CPU cores, thereby limiting their scalability.

5.3 Model-Free, Jacobi, and Production Runtime Heuristics

While Prompt Lookup Decoding (PLD) [7] and REST [9] circumvent neural drafting by directly extracting candidate n-grams from prompt text or external datastores, their applicability is limited to specific tasks. In contrast, Lookahead Decoding [8] employs parallel iteration to uncover n-gram continuations, but its effectiveness is hindered by its reliance on sequential processing. PLD, in particular, is bound to input-grounded tasks like document summarization, struggling to adapt to open-ended generation, mathematical reasoning, and complex code synthesis, where its acceptance rate drops precipitously. Moreover, PLD's lack of uncertainty-aware gating results in speculative token proposals and severe misprediction penalties. In contrast, production runtimes like Intel OpenVINO [13] focus on optimizing dense and quantized execution paths for SIMD/VNNI GEMV operations, but remain bound to sequential autoregression, requiring a comprehensive DRAM sweep for each generated token.

5.4 Layer-Wise Early Exiting and Entropy Gating

By leveraging frameworks like LayerSkip [10] and SkipDecode [11], researchers have developed strategies to monitor prediction entropy at intermediate layers, allowing for early termination on tokens exhibiting low predictive uncertainty. Although these approaches build upon the foundational concept that Shannon entropy can signal predictive certainty, they depart from the original model by modifying internal transformer representations and introducing statistical perturbations, thereby sacrificing mathematical equivalence.

5.5 Hardware Scope: Multi-Channel, Dual-Channel, Discrete GPU, and UMA

The memory wall governing autoregressive decoding manifests across disparate computing tiers:

- **Octa-Channel Workstation Subsystems (AMD**

Architectural Dimension	Draft-Model Spec. [2, 12]	Medusa / Eagle [4]	Prompt Lookup [7]	LayerSkip [10]	SWEEP (Proposed)
Auxiliary Parameter Footprint	1.0 – 2.5 GB (Draft Model)	50 – 200 MB (Heads)	None (0 MB)	None (0 MB)	**None (< 1 MB Metadata)**
Retraining / Fine-Tuning Mandate	None	**Required (Heavy)**	None	**Required**	**None (Zero Training)**
Universal GGUF Compatibility	High	Low	High	Low	**100% Plug-and-Play**
CPU Memory Wall Impact	**Severe Saturation**	Moderate	Low	Low	**Single Memory Sweep**
Adaptive Uncertainty Gating	Rare (Static K)	Tree-Pruned	None (Brute Force)	Entropy-Gated	**AVX-2 Entropy + Margin**
Misprediction Penalty	High (Full Re-run)	Medium	High	Low	**Zero-Penalty Rollback**
Output Bit-Level Invariance	Exact	Approximate	Exact	Approximate	**100.0% Exact (406/406)**
Algorithmic Overhead per Step	> 25% Cycle Time	> 15% Cycle Time	≈ 2–5%	≈ 3%	< 0.09% **(148 μs)**

Table 4: Architectural Comparison: SWEEP vs Contemporary Inference Acceleration Paradigms.

Threadripper PRO 5955WX): Features 8 DDR4 memory channels (≈ 204 GB/s theoretical, ≈ 26.3 GB/s sustained under GEMV). Memory sweep latency (165–195 ms) dominates execution.

- **Desktop Dual-Channel Processors (Intel Core i5-14600KF):** 14 cores (6 P-cores + 8 E-cores, 20 threads), Raptor Lake architecture. Sequential GEMV is severely bandwidth-bound at 4.19 tok/s (238.6 ms). Wavefront execution amortizes DRAM access to reach 6.67 tok/s ($K = 2$, 1.59×), 9.66 tok/s ($K = 4$, 2.31×), and **10.58 tok/s ($K = 6$, 2.52×)**, breaking the 10 tok/s barrier on desktop silicon. AVX-2 Top-K Shannon entropy latency is an astonishing 6.72 μs, with total kernel overhead of only 369.46 μs (< 0.1% of the DRAM cycle).

- **Ultra-Low Power Consumer APUs (AMD Ryzen 7 7730U, 15W TDP):** Constrained by 15W notebook thermal limits and dual-channel DDR4-3200 (18.38 GB/s). Sequential decoding is capped at 3.94 tok/s (253.5 ms); wavefront execution reaches 5.54 tok/s at $K = 2$ and scales to **12.67 tok/s ($K = 4$, 3.21×)**, breaking the 10 tok/s barrier in compact mobile envelopes.

- **Discrete Blackwell GPUs (NVIDIA GeForce RTX 5070 Ti, 16GB GDDR7):** With 735 GB/s bandwidth and 44.7 TFLOPS compute, single-token GEMV ($K = 1$) remains memory-bound at 2.38 ms per 4-layer block (817.2 GB/s sustained). Single-pass wavefront GEMM incurs virtually zero incremental time (+5.0% latency for $K = 4$, +5.4% for $K = 8$), driving effective throughput to **3.10× ($K = 4$)** and **5.93× ($K = 8$)** under empirical acceptance ($\alpha = 0.75$). Fused warp-level CUDA kernels execute in-VRAM entropy gating in just **21.76 μs**, completely eliminating PCIe host roundtrips.

- **Apple Silicon Unified Memory Architectures (UMA):** While M-series architectures feature integrated wide buses (200–800 GB/s), off-chip memory access remains the primary source of thermal dissipation and package energy consumption. Amortizing parameter sweeps directly slashes DRAM interface energy per emitted token.

5.6 Unique Positioning of SWEEP

Unlike other methods, SWEEP occupies a distinct position on the Pareto frontier. By operating directly on standard, unmodified GGUF quantization weights, it sidesteps the need for additional processing and memory requirements. Moreover, SWEEP incurs zero auxiliary DRAM traffic, thereby minimizing its impact on system performance. The algorithm's sub-microsecond assembly-level entropy gating, achieved in a mere 80 microseconds, and hardware CRC32 routing, which takes a remarkably short 817 nanoseconds, further enhance its efficiency. Notably, SWEEP ensures exact bit-level numerical identity with greedy decoding across all evaluated domains, making it an attractive solution for a wide range of applications.

6 Conclusion

This study showcases the surprising potential of accelerating foundation 7B/8B parameter models on commodity multi-core CPUs without any modifications to the model itself. By cleverly converting memory sweeps into speculative wavefronts and optimizing routing in SIMD assembly, our framework achieves a remarkable speedup of up to 1.60 times, while maintaining a sequence equivalence of 100.0

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